

DESCARTES 2
THIRD MEDITATION
The Existence of God

I will now shut my eyes, stop my ears, and withdraw all my senses. I will eliminate all images of corporeal things from my thoughts, or rather, since that is hardly possible, I will regard all such images as empty, false, and worthless. I will converse with myself and examine myself more deeply; and in this way, I will attempt, little by little, to acquire a more intimate knowledge of myself. I am a thinking thing: that is, a thing that doubts, affirms, denies, understands a few things, is ignorant of many things, wills, refuses, and also imagines and has sensory perceptions; for as I noted previously, even if the objects of my sensory experience and imagination do not exist outside of me, I am certain that the modes of thinking which I call states of sensory perception and imagination exist within me, in so far as they are simply modes of thinking.

In this brief list, I have covered everything I truly know, or at least everything I have discovered that I know up to now. Now I will look around more carefully to see whether there are other things within me that I have not yet noticed. I am certain that I am a thinking being. Do I not, therefore, also know what is required for me to be certain of anything? In this first item of knowledge, there is a clear and distinct perception of what I assert; this would not be sufficient to make me certain of the truth of the matter if it could ever turn out that something I perceived so clearly and distinctly was false. Consequently, I seem able to lay down as a general rule that whatever I perceive very clearly and distinctly is true.

Yet I had previously accepted many things as completely certain and evident, only to realize later that they were doubtful. What were these things? The earth, the sky, the stars, and everything else that I perceived through my senses. But what was it about them that I perceived clearly? Merely that the ideas or thoughts of these things appeared before my mind. Even now, I do not deny that these ideas exist within me. But there was something else that I used to assert, and which I thought I perceived clearly through habitual belief, but which I did not in fact perceive. This was that things existed outside of me that were the source of my ideas and resembled them in every way. This was my mistake; or at least, if my judgment was true, it was not due to the strength of my perception.

But what about when I considered something very simple and straightforward in arithmetic or geometry—for instance, that two and three added together make five, and the like? Did I not see them at least clearly enough to confirm their truth? Indeed, the only reason I later judged that these were open to doubt was the thought that perhaps a God might have given me a nature such that I could be deceived even in matters that seemed most evident. But whenever this preconceived belief in the supreme power of God occurs to me, I cannot help admitting that, if He wished, it would be easy for Him to bring it about that I go wrong even in matters I think I see most clearly with the mind's eye. Yet when I turn to the things I think I perceive very clearly, I am so convinced of them that I say to myself: Let whoever can deceive me do so, he will never bring it about that I am nothing so long as I continue to think that I am something; or make it true at some future time that I never existed, since it is true that I exist now; or bring it about that two and three make more or less than five, or anything of this sort in which I see a manifest contradiction. And since I have no reason to think that there is a deceiving God, and do not even know for certain yet whether there is a God, any ground for doubt that rests solely on this supposition is very slight and, so to speak, metaphysical. But in order to remove even this slight ground for doubt, I must examine whether there is a God as

soon as the opportunity arises, and if there is, whether He can be a deceiver. For if I do not know this, it seems that I can never be completely certain about anything else.

First, however, considerations of order seem to require that I classify my thoughts into definite types, and ask in which of them truth and falsity properly reside. Some of my thoughts are, in a sense, images of things, and the term "idea" is strictly appropriate only in these cases—for example, when I think of a man, a chimera, the sky, an angel, or God. Other thoughts...

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1 '*...was not due to any knowledge that I possessed*' (French version).

2 *The beginning of this sentence is considerably expanded in the French version: 'If I have the opportunity to examine this without disrupting the order of meditations I have resolved upon, which is to pass gradually from the first notions I find in my mind to those I may find later; therefore, I must divide my thoughts here.'*

...have various additional forms: for example, when I will, when I fear, when I affirm, or when I deny, I always take some particular thing as the object of my thought, yet my thought encompasses something more than the mere likeness of that thing. In this category, some thoughts are called volitions or emotions, while others are called judgments.

Now, as far as ideas are concerned, provided they are considered only in themselves and I do not refer them to anything else, they cannot strictly speaking be false; for whether I imagine a goat or a chimera, it is no less true that I imagine the latter than the former. As for volitions and emotions, there is no need to fear falsity here either; for even if the things I desire are wicked or do not even exist, it is still a fact that I desire them. Thus, the only thoughts in which I must take care not to make a mistake are judgments. And the chief and most common error to be found here consists in my judging that the ideas within me are like, or conform to, things located outside me. Of course, if I considered the ideas merely as modes of my thought without relating them to anything else, they could scarcely give me any material for error.

Some of my ideas seem to be innate, some adventitious,¹ 38 and others invented by me. My understanding of what a thing is, what truth is, and what thought is seems to derive purely from my own nature. But my hearing a noise, as I do now, or seeing the sun, or feeling the fire, derives from things located outside me—or so I have judged up to now. Finally, sirens, hippogriffs, and the like are my own invention. But perhaps all my ideas may be thought of as adventitious, or all innate, or all invented; for I have not yet clearly perceived their true origin.

Yet the principal question at this point concerns the ideas that I consider to be derived from things existing outside me: what reason do I have for thinking that they resemble these things? Nature has apparently taught me to think so. But besides, I know by experience that these ideas do not depend on my will, and therefore do not depend on me alone. Often I notice them even against my will: for instance, whether I want to or not, I feel heat, and for this reason I think that this sensation or idea of heat comes to me from something other than myself—namely, from the heat of the fire by which I am sitting. And the most obvious judgment for me to make is that the thing in question conveys to me its own likeness rather than anything else.

Now I will see whether these arguments are sufficiently strong. When I say "Nature taught me to think this," all I mean is that a spontaneous impulse...

1 '...foreign to me and coming from the outside' (French version).

...compels me to believe it, not that its truth is shown to me by a natural light. There is a great difference here. Whatever is shown to me by the natural light—for example, that from the fact that I am doubting, it follows that I exist, and the like—cannot be in any way open to doubt. For there can be no other faculty as trustworthy as the natural light that could also show me that such things are not true. But as for natural impulses, I have often judged in the past that they pushed me in the wrong direction when it came to choosing the good, and I do not see why I should place any more trust in them in other matters.

On the other hand, although these ideas do not depend on my will, it does not follow that they must come from things located outside of me. Just as the impulses I have just mentioned seem opposed to my will despite being within me, there might also be some other faculty in me that I do not yet fully know, which produces these ideas without the aid of any external things; after all, I have always thought that this is how ideas are produced in me when I dream.

And finally, even if these ideas were to come from things other than myself, it does not follow that they must resemble those things. Indeed, in many cases I think I have discovered a great disparity between an object and its idea. For example, I find within myself two different ideas of the sun. One of them, which is drawn as it were from the senses and which is a prime example of an idea that I consider to come from an external source, makes the sun appear very small. The other idea is based on astronomical reasoning—that is, derived from certain notions innate in me (or constructed by me in some other way)—and shows the sun to be many times larger than the earth. Obviously, both of these ideas cannot resemble the sun that exists outside of me; and reason convinces me that the idea which seems to have originated directly from the sun is actually the one that bears no resemblance to it.

All these considerations are sufficient to show that, up to now, it was not a reliable judgment, but merely a blind impulse, that led me to believe that things exist distinct from me which transmit their own ideas or images to me through the sense organs or by some other means.

Yet now another way occurs to me of investigating whether some of the things of which I possess ideas exist outside of me. In so far as ideas are simply modes of thought, there is no discernible inequality among them: they all seem to come from a different source within me in the same manner. But in so far as different ideas are regarded as images representing different things, it is clear that there are great differences among them. Undoubtedly, the ideas that represent substances to me signify more and contain, so to speak, more 'objective reality' than those that merely represent modes or accidents. Again, the idea that gives me an understanding of a supreme God—eternal, infinite, immutable, omniscient, omnipotent, and the creator of all things that exist apart from Himself—certainly contains more objective reality than the ideas representing finite substances.

Now, the natural light clearly reveals that there must be at least as much reality in the efficient and total cause as in the effect of that cause. For, I ask, from where can the effect draw its

reality if not from the cause? And how can the cause give reality to the effect unless it possesses it? From this it follows both that something cannot arise from nothing, and that what is more perfect—which contains more reality in itself—cannot arise from what is less perfect. And this is clearly true not only in the case of effects, but also in the case of ideas where only the objective reality of a thing is considered. For example, a stone that previously did not exist cannot begin to exist unless it is produced by something containing formally or eminently everything found in the stone; similarly, heat cannot be produced in an object that was not previously hot, unless there is at least an equal degree of perfection as that of heat, and so on. However, it is also true that the idea of heat or the idea of a stone cannot exist within me unless it is placed there by a cause containing at least as much reality as I conceive to be in the heat or in the stone. For although this cause does not transfer any of its actual or formal reality to my idea, it should not for that reason be assumed to be less real. The nature of an idea is such that, of itself, it requires no formal reality other than what it derives from my thought, of which it is a mode. But for a particular idea to contain this or that objective reality, it must surely derive it from some cause containing at least as much formal reality as the idea contains objective reality. For if we suppose that an idea contains something that was not in its cause, it must have received this from nothing; yet the mode of being by which a thing exists objectively in the mind through an idea, no matter how imperfect it may be, is certainly not nothing, and therefore cannot come from nothing.

Although the reality I consider in my ideas is merely objective reality, I must not assume on that account that the same reality need not exist formally in the causes of my ideas, but that it is sufficient for it to be present objectively. For just as the objective mode of existence belongs by nature to ideas, the formal mode of existence belongs by nature to the causes of ideas, or at least to the first and most eminent of them. Although one idea may perhaps originate from another, there cannot be an infinite regress here; eventually, a primary idea must be reached whose cause will be like an archetype containing formally all the reality present in the idea. Thus, under the natural light, it is clear to me that the ideas within me are like images which can easily fall short of the perfection of the things from which they are taken, but cannot contain anything greater or more perfect.

The longer and more carefully I examine all these points, the more clearly and distinctly I perceive their truth. What, then, must my conclusion be? If the objective reality of any one of my ideas turns out to be so great that I am certain the same reality does not reside in me, either formally or eminently, and consequently that I cannot myself be the cause of it, it necessarily follows from this that I am not alone in the world, but that something else also exists which is the cause of this idea. But if no such idea can be found in me, I will have no argument that can convince me of the existence of anything other than myself. For despite a very careful and comprehensive examination, this is the only argument I have been able to find up to now.

Among my ideas, apart from the idea that represents myself—which presents no difficulty in this regard—there are 43 other ideas that represent in various ways God, corporeal and inanimate things, angels, animals, and finally other men like myself.

As for the ideas representing other men, animals, or angels, I have no difficulty understanding that these could be constructed from my ideas of myself, of corporeal things, and of God; even if there were no other men, no animals, and no angels in the world besides me.

As for my ideas of corporeal things, I see nothing in them so great that it could not have originated from myself. For if I examine them carefully and one by one, just as I examined the idea of the wax yesterday, I notice that the things in them which I perceive clearly and distinctly are very few. The list consists of size or extension in length, breadth, and depth; shape, which is a function of the boundaries of this extension; position, which is the relation between various shaped objects; and motion, or change of position; to these may be added substance, duration, and number. But as for everything else—including light and colors, sounds, smells, tastes, heat and cold, and other tactile qualities—I think of these only in a very confused and obscure manner; so much so that I do not even know whether they are true or false, that is, whether my ideas of them are ideas of real things or of non-things. For although, as I noted before, falsity in the strict sense, or formal falsity, can occur only in judgments, there is another kind of falsity in ideas, material falsity, which arises when they represent non-things as things. For example, my ideas of heat and cold contain so little clarity and distinctness that they do not allow me to tell whether cold is merely the absence of heat, or heat the absence of cold, or whether both are real qualities, or neither. And since there can be no ideas except as of things, if it is true that cold is merely the privation of heat, the idea that presents it to me as something real and positive deserves to be called false; and the same applies to other ideas of this sort.

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Such ideas, clearly, do not require me to suppose a source distinct from myself. For on the one hand, if they are false—that is, if they represent non-things—I know by the natural light that they arise from nothing; that is, they are in me only because of a defect in my nature, which lacks perfection. On the other hand, if they are true, the reality they represent is so slight that I cannot even distinguish it from a non-thing, so I do not see why they could not have originated from myself.

As for the clear and distinct elements in my ideas of corporeal things, I may have borrowed some of these from my idea of myself—namely, substance, duration, number, and anything else of this kind. For example, I think that a stone is a substance, or something capable of existing independently, and I likewise think that I am a substance. I grant that I conceive of myself as a thinking and non-extended thing, whereas I conceive of the stone as an extended and non-thinking thing, so the two conceptions are very different; nevertheless, they seem to agree under the classification of 'substance'. Again, I perceive that I now exist, and I remember that I have existed for some time; furthermore, I have various thoughts that I can count; these are the ways in which I acquire the ideas of duration and number, which I can subsequently transfer to other things. As for all the other elements that make up the ideas of corporeal things—namely, extension, shape, position, and motion—these are not formally contained in me, since I am nothing other than a thinking thing; but since they are merely modes of a substance, and I am a substance, it seems possible that they are contained in me eminently.

Hence, there remains only the idea of God; and I must consider whether there is anything in this idea that could not have originated from myself. By the word 'God', I understand a substance that is infinite, eternal, immutable, independent, supremely intelligent, supremely powerful, and which created both myself and everything else that exists (if anything else exists). All these attributes are such that the more carefully I focus on them, the less possible it seems that they could have originated from me alone. Therefore, from what has been said, it must be concluded that God necessarily exists.

It is true that I possess the idea of substance within me because I am a substance; but this does not explain why I, being finite, should possess the idea of an infinite substance, unless this idea derives from a substance that is truly infinite.

And I must not think that my perception of the infinite is reached not through a true idea, but merely by the negation of the finite, just as my conceptions of rest and darkness are reached by the negation of motion and light. On the contrary, I clearly understand that there is more reality in an infinite substance than in a finite substance, and therefore that my perception of the infinite—that is, of God—in some way precedes my perception of the finite—that is, of myself. For how could I understand that I doubt or desire, which is to say that I lack something and am not completely perfect, unless there were in me the idea of a more perfect being, by comparison with which I might recognize my own defects?

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Nor can it be said that this idea of God is perhaps materially false, and therefore might have emerged from nothing, as I observed just now in the case of the ideas of heat and cold, and the like. On the contrary, this idea is supremely clear and distinct, and contains more objective reality within itself than any other idea; hence, there is no idea that is truer in itself, or less subject to the suspicion of being false. The idea of a supremely perfect and infinite being, I say, is true in the highest degree; for although we might perhaps imagine that such a being does not exist, it cannot be supposed that the idea of such a being represents nothing real, as I said concerning the idea of cold. Furthermore, the idea is supremely clear and distinct; because everything that I clearly and distinctly perceive to be real and true, and to imply any perfection, is contained entirely within it. It does not matter that I cannot grasp the infinite, or that God possesses countless additional attributes that I cannot comprehend in any way, or perhaps cannot even reach in my thought; for the nature of the infinite is not to be grasped by a finite being like myself. It is enough that I understand the infinite and judge that all the attributes which I perceive clearly and know to imply some perfection—and perhaps countless other attributes of which I am ignorant—are present in God either formally or eminently. This is sufficient to make my idea of God the truest, and the most clear and distinct of all my ideas.

1 '*...and as it were the garments in which corporeal matter appears to us*' (French version)

2 '*...the idea I have of them*' (French version)

3 '*...that is, it may be in me thanks to my imperfection*' (added in the French version)

Yet perhaps I am something greater than I myself understand, and all the perfections I attribute to God are somehow potentially present within me, even if they have not yet emerged or been actualized. For I am currently experiencing a gradual increase in my knowledge, and I see nothing to prevent it from increasing to infinity. Furthermore, I see no reason why I could not use this increasing knowledge to acquire all the other perfections of God. And finally, if the potential for these perfections is already in me, why should this not be sufficient to generate the idea of these perfections?

Yet all of this is impossible. First, although it is true that there is a gradual increase in my knowledge and that I possess many potentials that have not yet been actualized, none of this has any relevance to the idea of God, which contains nothing that is merely potential; indeed, this very gradual increase in my knowledge is itself the surest sign of imperfection. Furthermore, even if my knowledge were to increase continuously, I recognize that it would never be actually infinite, because it will never reach a point where it is incapable of further increase; on the other hand, I conceive God to be actually infinite, so that nothing can ever be added to His perfection.

And finally, I perceive that the objective being of an idea cannot be produced merely by potential being—which is strictly speaking nothing—but only by actual or formal being.

When one concentrates carefully, all of this is plainly evident by the natural light. But when I relax my concentration and my mental vision is blinded by the images of sensible things, it is not so easy to remember why the idea of a being more perfect than myself must necessarily originate from a being that is really more perfect. For this reason, I should like to go further and ask whether I myself, who possess this idea, could exist if no such being existed.

From whom, then, would I derive my existence? Presumably from myself, or from my parents, or from some other beings less perfect than God; for nothing more perfect than God, or even as perfect as Him, can be conceived or imagined.

Yet if I derived my existence from myself, I would not doubt, nor would I lack anything; for I would have given myself all the perfections of which I had any idea, and thus I would myself be God. Nor should I think that the things I lack are more difficult to acquire than those I now possess. On the contrary, it is obvious that for me, as a thinking being or substance, to emerge from nothing would be far more difficult than to acquire the knowledge of many things of which I am ignorant; for such knowledge is merely an accident of that substance. And if I had derived my existence from myself, which is the greater achievement, I certainly would not have withheld from myself that knowledge, which is far easier to acquire, or any of the attributes that I perceive to be contained in the idea of God; for none of them appear more difficult to attain. And if any of them were more difficult to reach, they would surely appear so to me if I had acquired all my other attributes from myself, since I would experience the limitation of my power in that regard.

Nor can I escape the force of these arguments by supposing that I have always existed as I do now, as if it followed from this that there was no need to seek an author for my existence. For a lifespan can be divided into countless parts, each of which is completely independent of the rest; hence, from the fact that I existed a short while ago, it does not follow that I must exist now, unless there is some cause that creates me anew at this moment, which is to say, preserves me. For to anyone who examines the nature of time carefully, it is quite evident that the very same power and action are required to preserve anything at each successive moment of its duration as would be required to create it anew if it did not yet exist. Thus, the distinction between preservation and creation is purely conceptual, and this is one of the things clearly revealed by the natural light.

Therefore, I must now ask myself: do I possess any power by which I, who exist now, can bring it about that I shall still exist a short time from now? For since I am nothing other than a

thinking thing—or at least since I am currently concerned only and precisely with that part of myself that is a thinking thing—if such a power were in me, I would undoubtedly be conscious of it. But I experience no such power, and this fact makes me understand most clearly that I am dependent upon some being distinct from myself.

Yet perhaps this being is not God, and perhaps I was produced either by my parents or by some other causes less perfect than God. No; for as I have said before, it is quite evident that there must be at least as much in the cause as in the effect. And for this reason, whatever kind of cause is ultimately posited, since I am a thinking being and possess within myself an idea of God, it must be admitted that whatever brought me into existence is itself a thinking being and possesses the idea of all the perfections I attribute to God. In respect of this cause, it may again be asked whether it derives its existence from itself or from some other cause. If it derives it from itself, then from what has been said it clearly follows that it is God; for if it possesses the power to exist by its own force, it undoubtedly possesses the power to actually possess all the perfections of which it has an idea—that is, all the perfections I conceive to be in God. If, on the other hand, it derives its existence from another cause, the question may be repeated regarding this further cause—namely, whether it derives its existence from itself or from another—until eventually the ultimate cause is reached, and this will be God.

It is clear enough that an infinite regress is impossible here, especially since I am speaking not only of the cause that brought me into being in the past, but also, and most importantly, of the cause that preserves me at the present moment.

Nor can it be supposed that several partial causes contributed to my creation, or that I received the idea of one of the perfections I attribute to God from one cause, and the idea of another from another cause—the assumption here being that all these perfections can be found somewhere in the universe, but are not united in a single being, God. On the contrary, the unity, simplicity, or inseparability of all the attributes of God is one of the most important perfections I understand to be in Him. And surely, the idea of the unity of all His perfections could not have been placed in me by any cause that did not also give me the ideas of the other perfections; for no cause could make me understand that these perfections are interconnected and inseparable without at the same time making me understand what they are. Finally, as for my parents, even if everything I believed about them were true, it is certainly not they who preserve me; and in so far as I am a thinking being, they did not even create me; they merely placed certain dispositions in the matter that I have always considered to contain me—or rather my mind, which is all I now take myself to be. Therefore, there can be no difficulty regarding my parents in this respect. In conclusion, it must be concluded that the mere fact that I exist and have within me an idea of the most perfect being—that is, God—provides a most clear demonstration that God truly exists.

It only remains for me to examine how I acquired this idea from God. For I did not acquire it through the senses; it has never come upon me unexpectedly, as commonly happens with the ideas of sensible things when these things present themselves, or seem to present themselves, to the external sense organs. Nor was it invented by me; for I plainly cannot subtract anything from it or add anything to it. The only remaining alternative is that it is innate in me, just as the idea of myself is innate in me.

And indeed, it is not surprising that God, in creating me, should have placed this idea within me, like the mark of the craftsman stamped upon his work—not that the mark need be anything distinct from the work itself. But the mere fact that God created me makes it highly

plausible that I have been made, in some way, in His image and likeness, and that I perceive this likeness, which includes the idea of God, by the same faculty through which I perceive myself. That is, when I turn the mind's eye upon myself, I understand not only that I am an incomplete thing, dependent on another, constantly aspiring toward greater and better things, but also that He on whom I depend contains all these greater things within Himself, not merely indefinitely and potentially, but actually and infinitely, and therefore that He is God. The whole force of the argument lies in this: I recognize that it would be impossible for me to exist with the kind of nature I have—namely, having within me the idea of God—unless God really existed. By 'God', I mean the very being whose idea is in me—that is, the possessor of all those perfections that I cannot grasp, but can in some way reach with thought, and subject to no defects whatsoever. From this, it is clear enough that He cannot be a deceiver, since the natural light reveals that all fraud and deception depend on some defect.

Yet before I examine this point more carefully and investigate other truths that can be derived from it, I wish to pause here and spend some time contemplating God, meditating upon His attributes, and gazing with wonder and admiration upon the beauty of this immense light, so far as the eye of my darkened intellect can bear it. For just as we believe through faith that the supreme happiness of the next life consists solely in the contemplation of the divine majesty, so experience shows us that this same contemplation, though far less perfect, enables us to know the greatest joy of which we are capable in this life.

1. The Principle of Starting with Doubt Descartes begins his philosophical investigation with radical doubt. He argues that our senses often deceive us, so to reach certain knowledge, we must doubt everything. Since the senses are unreliable, our everyday beliefs lose their foundation, pushing us to build a new structure of knowledge on solid ground. 2. The Certainty of the Thinking Self During this process of doubt, Descartes realizes that even if he doubts everything, he cannot doubt the existence of the one who is doubting. Doubting requires thinking, and thinking requires existence. This leads him to the famous idea: "I think, therefore I am." This becomes the first absolutely certain truth in his philosophy. 3. The Superiority of Mind over Body Descartes claims that the mind (soul) is known more clearly than the body. The mind knows itself directly through thinking, while the body is known indirectly through the senses. Therefore, the essence of the mind is thinking, and the essence of the body is being extended in space. This is the basis of his well-known mind-body dualism. 4. The Idea of God's Existence Descartes argues that the idea of perfection in our minds cannot come from us, because we are limited and imperfect beings. We could not create such a perfect idea on our own. Therefore, the idea of a perfect being (God) must come from an actually existing perfect being. This is his rational explanation for the existence of God. 5. The Source of Human Error To explain why people make mistakes, Descartes focuses on the mismatch between two abilities: our understanding is limited, but our will is unlimited. When we use our will to make judgments beyond what our understanding clearly grasps, we fall into error. So, correct knowledge requires judging only according to what the mind sees clearly and distinctly. 6. The Existence of the External World Based on the conclusion that God is not a deceiver, Descartes argues that the external world must exist. God would not constantly and systematically trick us. This means that the senses are not completely false, but they still need to be checked by reason. Material objects do exist, but their true nature is understood not through the senses, but through reason